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The bush is sweet

Author(S): Kristín Loftsdóttir

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 121

Culture (OWC): [Fulani \(MS11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1996-1998

Coverage Date: 1996 AD - 1998 AD

Place Coverage

Tchintabaraden Department, Tahoua Region, Niger

Section Title(S): CHAPTER 8: THE RAIN STARTS TO FALL

During this time of the year, the shallow ponds have formed and we stay quite close to them. The structure of the work and the social interaction is different. The camps are close to each other, meaning that every day there are interactions between people, both from my own lineage group and other groups. There is no need of going very far to get water but it is urgent to find nourishment for the animals. Dadi, one of my friends from the city who works as a migrant laborer, is back to stay at his mother's house for a few weeks. He is a little older than I am, and our relationship has developed into a kind of a joking relationship, almost as if we were cross-cousins (*denDiraaBe*). I find it is refreshing to have him so close by, and wish almost every day for his visits. His father is in Nigeria, and had left soon after Dadi was born. Thus, even though Dadi is over thirty years old, he has only seen his father a few times. His mother had attempted to do a *teega* marriage several times, but now she is back with her own lineage. She lives with her oldest son and his family. They have almost no animals, and thus make their house (*wuro*) with the brother of the old woman, who helps them with necessities.

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Dadi helps me with my embroidery, mainly through commenting on it and encouraging me. He helps me a little, his work being so much more beautiful than I suspect mine will ever be. Even though embroidery is not as common among men as among women, men seem to know how to do it well. "*Mariyama, debbo WoDaaBe*. Mariyama, the WoDaaBe woman", Dadi teases me when he sees me working on my embroidery. He knows a little English, and thus our conversation sometimes takes place in a mixture of Fulfulde and English. He stays at the house of his mother and brother but comes almost every afternoon in order to visit me.

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The day turns out to be hot. I have arranged an interview with an elderly man at his house. I usually have to make appointments with people in order to not disturb them too much with their work, and also in order to reach them before it gets dark. I tell Akali that I really want to bathe, and perhaps he can help me to find place where there are not many people. I go with him and Dadi to a large pond not far away. It is long like a stream, breaking into sections that stretch in all directions surrounded by trees and bushes. He finds me a small place located by one such branch of the pond, where the high leafy  122  123 bushes create almost a circular wall between the bush itself and the edge of the pond.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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